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Call Me Bud Powell.[7] You wanna imitate this?
Listen. Spree dee deet sprree deee whee spredeee whee deee

My calling card. The dialectic of silence.
The Sound approach. 45
Life one day will be filled even further with we numbers we song
But primitive place now, we wailing be kept underground.

But keep it in mind. Call me something Dukish. Something Sassy.[8]
Call me by my real name.[9] When the world change
We wailing be in it, help make it, for real time. 50

Call Me. I call you. We call We.
Say, Hey Wailers. Hey, Wailers.
Hey hey hey, Wailers. Wail On!

1982

7. Influential jazz pianist of the mid-1940s (1924–1966), composer of the Song "Wail" (1951).
8. Title of a Duke Ellington composition.
9. The opening line of Melville's *Moby-Dick* is "Call me Ishmael."

SONIA SANCHEZ

b. 1934

Among the most varied and enduring writers who came of age during the Black Arts era, Sonia Sanchez has stood at the crossroads of the many forces that lent this period of African American cultural ferment its aura of contradiction and possibility. An early celebrant of Black Power as a strictly gendered movement, Sanchez became a pioneering champion of black feminism alert to the bitter ironies of misogyny that often fueled the rhetoric of black "liberation." A onetime vociferous convert to the Nation of Islam, she became a voice for spiritual evolution encompassing ancestral African religiosity and Eastern modes of meditative discipline. A scholarly master of Euro-American literary and philosophical traditions, her voice exploded off the page with a vernacular gusto defiant of inherited conventions and expectations. And yet at every phase of her remarkable career as poet, playwright, short story writer, essayist, performer, political activist, and educator, Sanchez has remained a consistent exemplar of creativity rooted in respect for black communal values and insistent on self-transformation as foundation of collective realization.

Sanchez was born Wilsonia Benita Driver on September 9th 1934, in Birmingham, Alabama to Wilson L. Driver and Lena Jones Driver. Having lost her mother as a one-year-old, Sanchez spent her early years shuttling among different relatives as her father sought the means to reunify the scattered Driver family, an experience of domestic upheaval to which she would frequently return in her literary work. Those disruptive origins were given their most troubling focus when, at the age of six, Sanchez's grandmother died. In reaction, she began to stutter, which led her to "turn into myself and listen to those calling me." The heightened attention to speech, familial loss, and displacement that characterized Sanchez's childhood ultimately opened into the wide-ranging fluency, intimacy, and affirmation of her poetic voice.

When Sanchez was nine, her father moved the family to Harlem, New York in flight from the South: "I just came to New York to get my kids out of what was happening down there, school-wise and social-wise." Though still struggling with her speech impediment, Sanchez found her Harlem neighborhood an exhilarating environment of competing sights, sounds, smells, and appetites, being particularly attracted to the atmosphere of friendly challenge that characterized the male-dominated streets. It was to this environment of playful competition that she attributed the inspiration for exerting "sheer will power" through which she overcame her stuttering and began to excel in school. After obtaining a degree from Hunter College, Sanchez was selected to participate in a poetry workshop at New York University with Louise Bogan, whom she frequently credits as a crucial force in shaping her literary aspirations.

Sanchez emerged from these studies anxious to find her place in the "new wave" of contemporary black expression. In the 1960s, Sanchez published poetry and essays in numerous periodicals, including *The Liberator, Negro Digest,* and *Black Dialogue,* establishing her importance to the evolving "black aesthetic" program. These works display Sanchez as a political thinker bent on expressing social ideas in urgent and uncompromising terms. Fittingly, her first book, *Homecoming* (1969), was published by Broadside Press, a small black publishing venture that became a vehicle for many of the most powerful new voices of the Black Arts era.

Sanchez's importance to the Black Arts movement was not limited to her literary contributions. While figures like Amiri Baraka, Maulana Karenga, and Stokley Carmichael were building revolutionary organizations that aimed to supplant white power structures, Sanchez embedded herself in the mainstream education system with the intent of transforming its mission and identity. Joining other activists at San Francisco University, Sanchez became a leader in the effort to establish Black Studies, which not only provided a new platform for probing the history and meaning of race in global perspective but also issued a fundamental challenge to American universities as engines of class reproduction and racial domination. When Sanchez joined the Nation of Islam in 1972, what appeared to be a sudden swerve of purpose and affiliation could also be seen as a continuation of her quest for an institutional form of black solidarity based on promotion of alternative historical understanding and a deeply pedagogical practice. Serving as the Nation of Islam's Director of Culture, Sanchez rose to prominence as an NOI spokesperson, writing frequently about the black family for the organization's street newspaper *Muhammad Speaks.* By this time Sanchez was herself a mother, having had her daughter Anita with her first husband, Albert Sanchez, and then giving birth to twin sons, Morani Neusi and Mungu Neusi, with her second husband, poet Etheridge Knight. Sanchez's experience as a mother quickened in her a passion for understanding maternal sensibility as a link to ancestral power and conduit to revolutionary regeneration. The relation of mother and child emerges in the 1970s as a key motif of her poetry, colored by a "blues consciousness" strong enough to face searing trauma without falling into the stuttering disablement of despair.

After her marriage to Knight failed, Sanchez's work sought new ways to develop broad themes of social and spiritual struggle from the roots of personal anguish. In *A Blues Book for Blue Black Magical Women* (1974), for example, a semi-autobiographical narrative becomes Sanchez's vehicle for reflecting on the history of black women's suffering and endurance that takes on the sweep of mythic epic. At the same time, the teacherly impulse that activated her leadership in the Black Studies movement and characterized her work as Nation of Islam advocate fed her efforts to magnify her politics by passing to succeeding generations the lessons of struggle. Bringing youngsters into the communal circle of Black Arts literary experience, Sanchez wrote several children's books—*It's a New Day* (1971), *The Adventures of Fathead, Smallhead, and Squarehead* (1973), and *A Sound Investment* (1980)—that deploy popular idioms to imbue her narratives with practical and spiritual learning.

As Sanchez's poetry developed, this effort to merge intimate feeling and public implication led to innovative explorations of vernacular expression that helped define the "voice" of the Black Arts era. Defying conventions of standard verse form, and flouting decorum with bursts of profanity (often in slyly humorous ways), Sanchez insisted that feeling dictate the length of the poetic line and that enunciation take precedence over propriety in determining poetic meaning. The poems collected in *We a BaddDDD People* (1970) capture the intersection of militant assertion and street-wise articulation through which Sanchez achieved a partnership of public meaning and personal expression. And as with *Homecoming,* this second book of poems sought to activate in its audience an awakening to the social import of private experience: "My first books were about being aggressive and confrontational. They were books that said 'By golly by gee, I didn't know all this happened to us as a people. Now I'm going to put it right up in your face, and tell you what it's all about.'"

With its continued maturation, Sanchez's work expanded its allusive universe, encompassing aspects of African cosmology, Eastern religion, and Euro-American history into writing that never loses its grounding in the African American tradition. If the early work is powerful for its unrelenting disparagement of oppressive "witeness," it also bears in its punishing repetitions and relatively circumscribed imagery traces of the girlhood Sanchez seeking to release herself from the stammering hesitations of constrained consciousness. As her poetry becomes more thematically capacious, the stutter modulates into a fluent and varied voice, blending the confident tones of Swahili praise song with blues and gospel intonations into a newfound spiritual confidence. As early as *A Blues Book for Blue Black Magical Women,* Sanchez begins to cultivate a poetic and narrative stance that remains defiant and accusatory while reflecting a widening vision of how gender, race, class, place, history, and disposition shape the crucible in which individual and collective identities are forged. While locating new resources of lyric intimacy, increasingly her work also exerts a critical pressure on more narrow, especially misogynistic, features of Black Arts ideology and writing, inviting advocates of revolutionary black thought to admit the healing powers of African-derived wisdom into the framework of radical contemporary action. By the time of the long poem *Does Your House Have Lions?* (1997), an emotionally powerful account of her brother's fatal struggle with the AIDS virus, Sanchez has shaped the stuttering impulse into a means for speaking the unspeakable and facing tragedy with indomitable courage.

Sanchez's drama and prose have been as effective as her poetry in shaping this evolving vision. In such tightly designed plays as *Sister Son/ji* (1969), Sanchez challenges the masculinist ethos of much Black Arts era drama by fashioning women protagonists who, despite subjection to physical, mental, and economic violence, assert the primacy of their own "revolutionary" knowledge and desire. These plays champion the "blackness" of the everyday ghetto, finding there a radical spirit embodied in women struggling to survive the ravages of modern urban existence. That spirit of defiant survival likewise animates much of Sanchez's prose work, such as *homegirls and handgrenades* (1985), which offers a panoramic vision of a black woman's encounter with the full resources of black tradition.

No matter the poetic or narrative structure in which she is working, Sanchez is above all directed by the sound of words as they flit between the anchoring page and the activated voice. "When I write I always read my poems aloud," she has said. Famous for the dynamism of her public readings, Sanchez has long mastered the full range of African and African American vocal resources probed through study and tested by experience, moving effortlessly from exuberant chant or celebratory shout to anguished cry or whispered prayer. This sonic range has allowed her to bring to life a gallery of vivid personages, from the "badd" warrior sisters of her early poetry to the no less fiery, but also meditative maternal griots of more recent work. Having become now what she terms an "ordained stutterer," Sanchez offers her audiences the privileged practice of "speaking in tongues" as she continues to confront the possibilities of renewal within searing legacies of traumatic history.

[*SCREAM—HEY—SCREAM—HEY.*]

Yes. u, death. i'm calling yr/name. why not me? Stay away from my family. i've given u one son—one warrior for yr/apprenticeship. git stepping death for our tomorrows will be full of life/living/births.

if he keeps the devil/woman then he shd be made to leave. Yes. he must go. Mume, tell me what are all these deaths for, with more likely to come? so he can feel sorry for a devil/woman and bring her whiteness among all this BLK/NESS.

he feels sorry for her. and what abt our teachings. have we forgotten so soon that we hate devils. that we are in a death/struggle with the beasts. if she's so good, so liberal, send her back to her own kind. Let her liberalize them. Let her become a camp follower[5] to the hatred that chokes white/america. yes I wd vote to send yr/partner to certain death if he tries to keep her.

these mississippi hills will not give up our dead. my son/our son did not die for integration. u must still remember those ago/yrs when we had our blk/white period. they died for the right of blk/children to run on their own land and let their bodies explode with the sheer joy of living. of being blk/and many children have died and these brown hills and red gullies[6] will not give up our dead. and neither will i. [*The sounds of guns, planes are heard.* SISTER SON/JI *moves slowly to the dressing/table. The war/sounds decrease and a sound like Coltrane mixed with drums begins slowly, tiredly. She puts on the gray/haired/wig, takes off the gun and baby carrier—and puts on the make/up of all the yrs she has gathered. Then she turns around in the chair and stares at the audience.*]

SISTER SON/JI Death is a five o'clock door forever changing time. And wars end. Sometimes too late. i am here. still in mississippi. Near the graves of my past. We are at peace. the state supports me and others like me and i have all the time i want to do what all old/dying people do. Nothing. but I have my memories. [*Rises*] Yes. hee, hee. i have my sweet/astringent memories becuz we dared to pick up the day and shake its tail until it became evening. a time for us. blk/ness. blk/people. Anybody can grab the day and make it stop. can u my friends? or maybe it's better if i ask: WILL YOU?

1969

a/coltrane/poem[1]

my favorite things[2]
is u/blowen
yo/favorite/things.
stretchen the mind
till it bursts past the con/fines of 5

5. Civilian who follows an army unit to assist or exploit military personnel; here, a prostitute.
6. "Brown hills and red gullies": citation from 1968 poem "The Idea of Ancestry" by Etheridge Knight (1931–1991), Sanchez's husband at the time of the play's composition.
1. John Coltrane (1926–1967), jazz saxophonist of the 1960s "new wave" celebrated for his virtuosity, experimental zeal, and spiritual dedication.
2. "My Favorite Things": 1961 Coltrane composition that refers in its title and melody to a song by Richard Rodgers (1902–1976) and Oscar Hammerstein II (1895–1960) from their 1959 musical *The Sound of Music*.

solo/en melodies.
to the many solos
of the
mind/spirit.
are u sleepen (to be
are u sleepen sung
brotha john softly)
brotha john[3]
where u have gone to.
no mornin bells[4]
are ringen here. only the quiet
aftermath of assassinations.[5]
but i saw yo/murder/
the massacre
of all blk/musicians. planned
in advance.
yrs befo u blew away our passsst
and showed us our futureeeeee
screech screeech screeeeech screeech
a/love/supreme. alovesupreme a lovesupreme.[6]
A LOVE SUPREME
scrEEEccCHHHHH screeeeEEECHHHHHHHH
sCReeeEEECHHHHHH SCREEEECCCCHHHH
SCREEEEEEEECCCHHHHHHHHHHH
a lovesupremealovesupremealovesupreme[7] for our blk
people.
BRING IN THE WITE/MOTHA/fuckas
ALL THE MILLIONAIRES/BANKERS/ol
MAIN/LINE/ASS/RISTOCRATS (ALL
THEM SO-CALLED BEAUTIFUL
PEOPLE)
WHO HAVE KILLED
WILL CONTINUE TO
KILL US WITH
THEY CAPITALISM/18% OWNERSHIP
OF THE WORLD.
YEH. U RIGHT
THERE. U ROCKEFELLERS. MELLONS
VANDERBILTS
FORDS.[8]

3. English rendition of the French nursery melody "Frère Jacques," traditionally sung in a round.
4. With a pun on *mourning*.
5. Reference to the sequence of assassinations that marked the 1960s: John F. Kennedy (1917–1963), 35th president of the United States (1960–63); Malcolm X (1925–1965), black nationalist minister of the Nation of Islam and human rights activist; Martin Luther King Jr. (1929–1968), cofounder of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference and civil rights leader; and Robert F. Kennedy (1925–1968), U.S. attorney general (1961–64), New York senator (1964–68), and, at the time of his death, presidential aspirant.
6. "A Love Supreme": An elaborate, four-part Coltrane composition; written partly in celebration of his triumph over drug and alcohol addiction, this musical suite is organized as a kind of religious journey moving from "Acknowledgement" through "Resolution" and "Pursuance" to a concluding "Psalm."
7. In this and other passages of the poem, Sanchez evokes key features of Coltrane's style: the legato compression of notes played at breakneck speed, sometimes called "sheets of sound"; sustained, tonally varied wailings or "screeching"; and rapid alterations of length, pitch, and emphasis.
8. Prominent American families who amassed fortunes during the period of industrial expansion from the mid-19th to mid-20th centuries in oil production and banking (Rockefellers), steel production and banking (Mellons), railroads (Vanderbilts), and automobile manufacturing (Fords).

yeh.
GITem.
PUSHem/PUNCHem/STOMPem. THEN
LIGHT A FIRE TO
THEY pilgrim asses.
TEAROUT they eyes.
STRETCH they necks
till no mo
raunchy sounds of MURDER/
POVERTY/STARVATION
come from they
throats.
screeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeCHHHHHHHHHHHH
SCREEEEEEEEEEEEEECHHHHHHHHHHH
screeEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEECCCCHHHHHHHH
SCREEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEE
EEEEEECHHHHHHHHHHH
BRING IN THE WITE/LIBERALS ON THE SOLO SOUND
OF YO/FIGHT IS MY FIGHT
SAXOPHONE.
TORTURE
THEM FIRST AS THEY HAVE
TORTURED US WITH
PROMISES/
PROMISES. IN WITE/AMURICA. WHEN
ALL THEY WUZ DOEN
WAS HAVEN FUN WITH THEY
ORGIASTIC DREAMS OF BLKNESS.
(JUST SOME MO
CRACKERS[9] FUCKEN OVER OUR MINDS.)
MAKE THEM
SCREEEEEEAM
FORGIVE ME. IN SWAHILI.
DONT ACCEPT NO MEA CULPAS.[1]
DON'T WANT TO HEAR
BOUT NO EUROPEAN FOR/GIVE/NESS.
DEADDYINDEADDYINDEADDYINWITEWESTERN
SHITTTTTT
(softly da-dum-da da da da da da da da da/da-dum-da
till it da da da da da da da da da
builds da-dum- da da da
up) da-dum. da. da. da. this is a part of my
favorite things.
da dum da da da da da da
da da da da
da dum da da da da da da
da da da da

9. White people (derogatory slang).
1. Formal acknowledgments of fault (from Latin—*mea* "my," *culpa*: "guilt"); "Swahili": Bantu language spoken by various ethnic groups in East and Southeast Africa.

da dum da da da da
da dum da da da da– – – – –
(to be rise up blk/people
sung de dum da da da da
slowly move straight in yo/blkness
to tune da dum da da da da
of my step over the wite/ness
favorite that is yesssss terrrrrr day
things.) weeeeeeee are tooooooday.
(f da dum
a da da da (stomp, stomp) da da da
s da dum
t da da da (stomp, stomp) da da da
e da dum
r) da da da (stomp) da da da dum (stomp)
weeeeeeeee (stomp)
areeeeeeeee (stomp)
areeeeeeeee (stomp, stomp)
tooooooday (stomp.
day stomp.
day stomp.
day stomp.
day stomp!)
(soft rise up blk/people. rise up blk/people
chant) RISE. & BE. what u can.
MUST BE.BE.BE.BE.BE.BE.BE-E-E-E-E-
BE-E-E-E-E-E-
yeh. john coltrane.
my favorite things is u.
showen us life/
liven.
a love supreme.
for each
other
if we just
lisssssssSSSTEN.

1970

TCB[1]

wite/motha/fucka
wite/motha/fucka
wite/motha/fucka
whitey.
wite/motha/fucker
wite/motha/fucker
wite/motha/fucker

1. Vernacular acronym for "Taking Care of Business" (to perform effectively or responsibly); in the 1960s, TCB also meant "Together Collected and Black."